

TABLE OF GODS



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Sumerian Renaissance Cake

“To test a man’s character, give him power,” the saying goes. But as history has taught us, that’s usually a bad idea. Most men can’t handle absolute power. A rare exception, however, was King Ur-Nammu who lived over 4,000 years ago. Despite being the most powerful ruler in Mesopotamia, Ur-Nammu never lost his humanity.

Unlike the earlier king, Naram-Sin, who likened himself to the gods, King Ur-Nammu saw himself as a shepherd. He enacted laws to protect women and the vulnerable. In his own words, “I did not deliver the orphan to the rich, I did not deliver the widow to the mighty, I did not deliver the man with one sheep to the man with one ox.”

Ur-Nammu’s law code was notably more humane than Hammurabi’s famous “eye for an eye” code, written some 300 years later. In contrast, Ur-Nammu’s law number 23 reads: “If a man causes the loss of another man’s eye, he will pay thirty shekels.”

Even in art, Ur-Nammu showed his humanity by choosing to be portrayed carrying tools alongside his construction workers or standing in prayer before seated gods.

King Ur-Nammu’s reign also marked the beginning of the Sumerian renaissance—a time when literature, culture, and even the art of baking flourished. A clay tablet found in Ur from this era reveals that “cakes have gone to the palace.”

The text is followed by an ingredient list including first-quality dates, Smyrna raisins, white cheese, and butter. We can only guess the rest. But a cake sent to the palace during the Sumerian renaissance wasn’t just any cake.

PS: If you bake this cake, I’d love to hear about it. Send me an email at arim@tableofgods.com and include a photo if you can 😊

Naptunu qarrub,
Arim

Origin: Ur 2098 BC
Prep time: 2 hours 20 minutes
Rise time: 1 hour 20 minutes
Cook time: 50 minutes
Serves: 12

Ingredients

Cake Base

¼ cup (50 g) pitted dates
¼ cup (40 g) raisins
¼ cup (60 ml) hot water
3 cups (430 g) all-purpose flour
2¼ teaspoons instant yeast
12 tablespoons (170 g) salted butter
1½ cups (355 ml) whole milk
¼ cup (80 g) honey
2 large eggs at room temperature
Pinch of table salt

Decorations

1¼ cups (180 g) all-purpose flour, plus more as needed
9 tablespoons (125 g) salted butter, well chilled
1 tablespoon (15 ml) cold water
1 tablespoon (20 g) honey
½ teaspoon ground cardamom

Filling and Frosting

2 cups (475 ml) heavy whipping cream
3½ ounces (100 g) cream cheese
5 tablespoons (100 g) honey
1¼ cups (370 g) unsweetened apricot jam

Instructions

1. In a medium bowl, combine the dates, raisins, and hot water and allow to soak for 5 minutes. Process into a paste using an immersion blender, then set aside.
2. In a large bowl, mix the flour and yeast. Set aside.
3. Melt the butter in a small pot over low heat. Add the milk and honey to the pot and heat the mixture until it is warm to the touch, about 99°F (37°C).
4. In a large bowl, beat the eggs until light and fluffy with a hand mixer.
5. Add the butter mixture and three-quarters of the flour mixture to the bowl with the eggs and mix.
6. Add the salt, the remaining flour, and the date-and-raisin paste and continue mixing until there are no traces left of the flour.
7. Cover the batter with a kitchen towel and let it rise in a warm place for 1 hour, or until it has doubled in size.
8. Line a 9-inch (22 cm), 3-inch-high (7½ cm) springform pan with a removable bottom with parchment paper.
9. Transfer the batter to the pan. Cover the pan with a kitchen towel and let it rise for another 20 minutes.
10. Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C).
11. Bake in the middle of the oven for 35–40 minutes, or until golden and a toothpick comes out clean.
12. Remove from the oven and let the cake rest for about 5 minutes.
13. Run a knife around the edges to loosen the cake and remove the springform pan. Invert the cake onto a wire rack lined with parchment paper to keep the top flat. Allow it to cool completely.
14. To level the cake, place it on a stable surface. Use a serrated knife to trim the top for a flat surface. Next, visually divide the cake horizontally into thirds, or for added precision, mark your cutting lines with toothpicks around the cake's circumference before slicing. Gently slice horizontally to separate it into three even layers, moving carefully to maintain uniform thickness.
15. To make the decorations, in a bowl, crumble together the flour and butter with your fingers until you have a breadcrumb-like texture.
16. Add the water, honey, and cardamom and knead the mixture into a dough. Cover the dough with plastic wrap and chill it in the refrigerator for 30 minutes.
17. Place the dough on parchment paper and dust it with flour. Roll it out thinly, to about ¼ inch (½ cm) thick.

18. Place the parchment paper with the dough on a baking sheet and refrigerate it for 10 minutes. This will make cutting the shapes out much easier.
19. Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C).
20. Use parchment-paper templates to cut out 20 diamonds 2¾ inches high and 2 inches wide (7 × 5 cm), 20 triangles 1¼ inches (3 cm) on all sides, and 15 leaves ¾ inch long and ½ inch wide (2 × 1 cm) from the dough. You may have to reroll the scraps to have enough dough for all the decorations.
21. Line another baking sheet with parchment paper and transfer the cutout shapes to the clean sheet. Bake in the middle of the oven for 5–8 minutes, or until slightly golden. Set aside to cool.
22. To make the filling, whip the heavy cream and cream cheese to stiff peaks with a hand mixer, then gently fold in the honey.
23. Place one cake layer on a cake plate.
24. Spread about ¾ cup (175 ml) of the cream filling evenly on top of the cake layer.
25. Spread half of the apricot jam. Then add the second layer of cake and repeat.
26. Add the third layer of cake, and cover the entire cake with the remaining cream filling.
27. Decorate the cake with the baked pastry shapes.